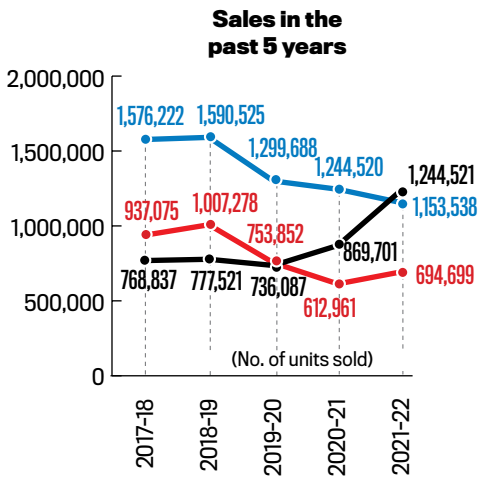
WHEN KHUSHBOO SINGH, 37, AND HER husband Shubham Tandon, 39, decided to go for a bigger car four years ago as a replacement for their Maruti Swift, they chose a Renault Duster SUV. It served the couple, then based in Gurugram, well, since it gave them ample space to accommodate their two pet golden retrievers and other close relatives when they went on long drives. The couple, who moved to Pune earlier this year, as Tandon got a job with the city-based Bajaj Finserv, decided to upgrade to a Hyundai Alcazar, a seven-seater that cost them Rs 25 lakh, since the dogs needed more space as they grew up. They paid for the car, delivered to them in August-end, partly from the money they got by selling the old car, and the rest from their savings. "The air conditioning in the new car is really strong and that bodes well for our pets. There is also more space for passengers and luggage, helping us to go on long trips with our pets and extended family," says Singh. The new car, like the earlier Duster, is an automatic, saving them the trouble of shifting gears frequently in city traffic.

For long, the Indian car market was a haven for small cars as companies fought it out for a share in the affordable cars segment. Led by Maruti Suzuki, which rolled out its fabled affordable Maruti 800 in 1983, vehicle manufacturers, both domestic and multinationals, wooed millions of consumers with their low-priced cars. Entry-level hatchbacks (with a two-box body, one for the engine and one for passengers, as compared to a sedan's three-box body for engine, passengers and trunk) ruled the roost, fuelled by a rising middle class and a burgeoning auto finance sector. So much so that in 2017-18, hatchbacks boasted of nearly half (48 per cent) the passenger car market in India. That meant nearly 1.6 million hatchbacks sold

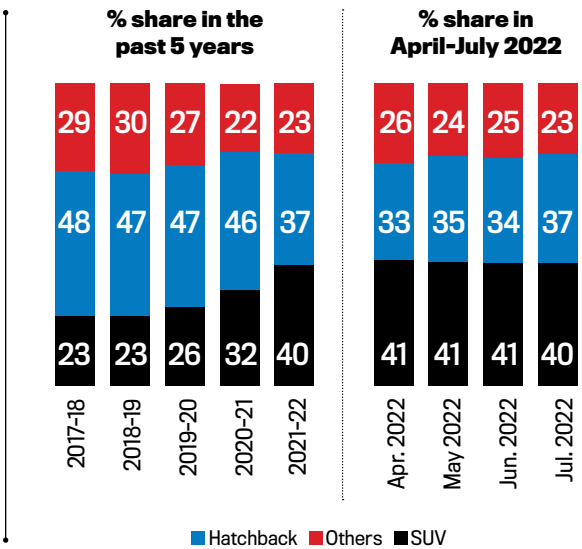




HOW SUVs HAVE PIPPED HATCHBACKS IN SALES



Source: JATO Dynamics



Graphics by ASIT ROY



KIA SELTOS
₹9.89 LAKH



*All prices are ex-showroom, for entry-level variant